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They really shouldn't have done this

The ethical dilemma in this case wherein National Security Adviser Michael Waltz created a Signal group chat named "Houthi PC small group" to coordinate discussions on planned military operations against the Houthi rebels in Yemen. This group included Vice President JD Vance, Secretary of State Marco Rubio, Secretary of Defense Pete Hegseth, and other senior officials. During this setup, Waltz inadvertently added Jeffrey Goldberg, editor-in-chief of *The Atlantic*, to the chat. Unaware that Goldberg had been added, officials shared sensitive operational details, including specific targets, weapons systems, and attack sequencing. This situation presents several ethical questions: Should the reporter publish the information, balancing the public interest against national security risks? Should the officials continue using encrypted chats for sensitive discussions, prioritizing security over transparency? Should they acknowledge their mistake publicly or try to contain the situation?

From a Kantian ethics perspective, duty and universal moral rules are the key principles. If transparency is a fundamental duty, the reporter should publish the information regardless of the consequences. However, revealing military plans before they are taken out could endanger lives. Kantian ethics could argue that the duty to protect life outweighs the duty to inform. However, Kantian ethics could just as quickly argue publishing all of the sensitive data immediately due to its possible view on the rules of journalism and when to publish. On the other hand, the officials have a duty to national security and ethical decision-making. Using a private chat for such discussions violates many rules of accountability. The officials, if following Kantian ethics, would not perform this action as it violates the rules of the shared information and the rules of the posts they hold. In a Kantian View, the reporter should consider whether publishing respects the rights of all stakeholders.

Utilitarianism evaluates actions based on consequences, aiming for the greatest good for the most significant number. It could be justified if publishing the information prevents an unjust military action or promotes government accountability. However, if it risks the lives of soldiers or civilians, withholding the story might be the better choice. For the officials, the risks taken and actions undertaken could pose a massive security risk if left unchecked. Habits like these foster recklessness and will erode public trust. The likely utilitarian decision would involve weighing whether publication prevents more significant harm than it causes through released info and public sentiment. At the same time, Utilitarianism also calls to ensure officials implement better protocols.

Virtue ethics focuses on character and moral integrity. A virtuous journalist must balance honesty, courage, and responsibility. Publishing classified information recklessly might not align with the wisdom of virtue ethics, but suppressing a vital story that needs to be shared like this would betray integrity. A Virtuous person, in this case, should come out with the massively important information while also checking through the data and redacting or waiting to share certain details depending on if there would be any information risk. The officials, meanwhile, should embody prudence and responsibility. Conducting military planning in a casual Signal chat demonstrates extreme recklessness while handling classified information with incorrect care reflects poorly on their character and ethical standing in this system. A Virtuous person would follow the rules of top secret data and not transmit it in a place where a journalist could be added, let alone is added. The virtue ethics approach suggests the reporter should engage in responsible journalism while officials should adopt more secure and ethical communication practices.

These perspectives do not fully agree on the reporter's end. Kantian ethics may call for strict duty adherence, whether protecting national security or upholding transparency. Utilitarianism is more flexible and depends on the general consequences of publication. Virtue ethics focuses on integrity and suggests a balanced, responsible approach. However, all three ethical perspectives generally agree that the officials should not have used an unsecured, non-governmental platform like Signal for discussing classified military operations. Kantian ethics emphasizes a duty to uphold security protocols, Utilitarianism highlights the massive potential security risks outweighing any convenience gained, and virtue ethics stresses the importance of prudence and responsibility in decision making. While they may differ on how the journalist should handle the information, they align in condemning the officials' communication choices.

If I were the reporter, I would likely take a modified utilitarian and virtue ethics approach. I would seek more information to determine what parts of the publication could cause unnecessary harm, avoid revealing specifics like names and local informants that could endanger lives, and make sure to report after the strikes have happened to ensure nobody in the strike is put at undue risk and ensure responsible reporting that accurately portrays the mistake. If I were one of the officials, I would not have used Signal to send info on upcoming strikes while ensuring I knew the rules of classified and top-secret information.

Someone could argue the opposite position in different ways. Some might say that the officials were not sharing classified intelligence but engaging in high-level strategic discussions that did not include sensitive operational details. They could claim that informal communication among decision-makers is necessary for efficiency and does not inherently compromise security. On the other hand, even if the officials claim they were not sharing classified intelligence, the information they discussed posed a massive security risk because it detailed future military strikes. Operational planning, including target selection, weapons systems, and sequencing of attacks, is inherently sensitive. Even if not explicitly marked as "classified," such discussions, if

leaked, could compromise missions, endanger personnel, and give adversaries a strategic advantage. The fact that a journalist was mistakenly included in the chat demonstrates the reckless nature of using a platform like Signal in the first place. Secure and officially sanctioned communication channels exist for a reason, and failing to use them undermines national security and responsible leadership.s. This divergence in viewpoints on the journalist side, while the other side has such a unified disagreement with the decision to use Signal, is why this situation is an interesting ethical dilemma.